Influence



Massey 2025

Next Class

Do the Moses & Sadik Kahn readings

- 1 chapter on Robert Moses from Caro book
- 1 chapter & 1 article on Janette Sadik-Kahn (JSK)

Complete the Survey (about Moses & JSK)

- Due 8am Monday

Other assignments next week

Leverage inventory

- Email invitation from Wharton People Lab tomorrow (March 23)
- Invitations out to raters by next Friday (March 31)

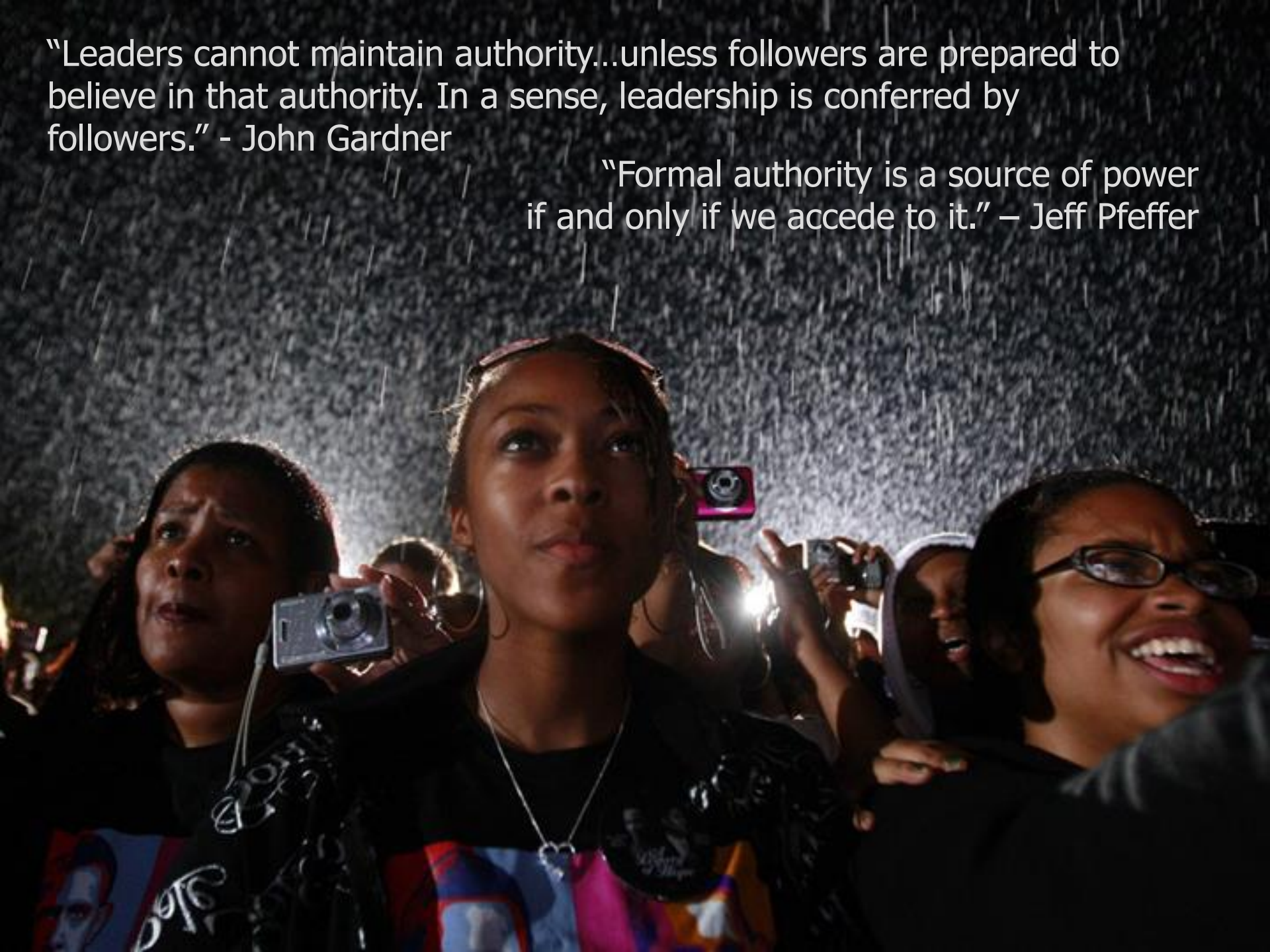
Introductory video

- Details next week

Optional exercise with the law school

- Thursday, Oct 30, 1:00-2:50p, Huntsman
- Limited to the first 19 students who sign up
  - Will send link by Canvas announcement

Our first framework…


"Leaders cannot maintain authority…unless followers are prepared to believe in that authority. In a sense, leadership is conferred by followers." - John Gardner
"Formal authority is a source of power if and only if we accede to it." – Jeff Pfeffer

Power and Authority

Understanding obedience – the acceptance of authority – is vital to an understanding of politics.

So why do people "obey"?

The Bases of Social Power

French & Raven's classic model

- Reward Power
- Coercive Power
- Expert Power
- Referent Power
- Legitimate Power

Reward Power

What do "rewards" look like in professional settings?

They take many different shapes

- Compensation
- Promotions
- Perqs
- Projects

…

- Introductions
- Information
- Etc.

Coercive Power

Also multidimensional

Def: The ability – and willingness(!) – to impose costs on another person.

French & Raven: The use of power invokes resistance. Especially coercive power.

- Use the minimum coercion necessary to do the job.

Expert Power

Heuristic: Works through confidence

- Performance / Reputation
- Functional Status – Someone knows something you don't
  - Important role for accreditation (e.g., doctor, technician)
- "Probably the principle type of authority that operates…in society in general," Simon et al.

Expert Power

Often the first source of power available to a young executive…

… and the most directly in your control.

Why do people knock on your office door?

- What sources of expert power do you have?
- What sources could you have?

Referent Power

Identification with, a feeling of one-ness with, or a desire for it.

Identification

- A heuristic: Wanting somebody else to like you, or wanting them to include you in some way.

Often outside the awareness of those influenced

Referent Power

What can we do to cultivate referent power?

Legitimate Power

"Should", "ought to", "has a right to"

- Most people are indoctrinated "to play according to the rules of the game"
- One of the most important sources of the authority of the hierarchical superior
  - Regardless of confidence, identification or sanctions
- Hierarchical Status – Confidence that a higher up is…
  - …reasonably capable else she wouldn't be there
  - …privy to information that makes her better able to make the decision

Legitimate Power

Generally an instinctive, automatic deference

As with many instinctive behaviors, with more time it can change.

Longer lasting in cultures with a higher "power distance" (e.g., Saudi Arabai, Nigeria)

Some of the subtleties in French & Raven

Use of power – especially coercive – can invoke opposing resistance

Types of power differ in their degree of internalization

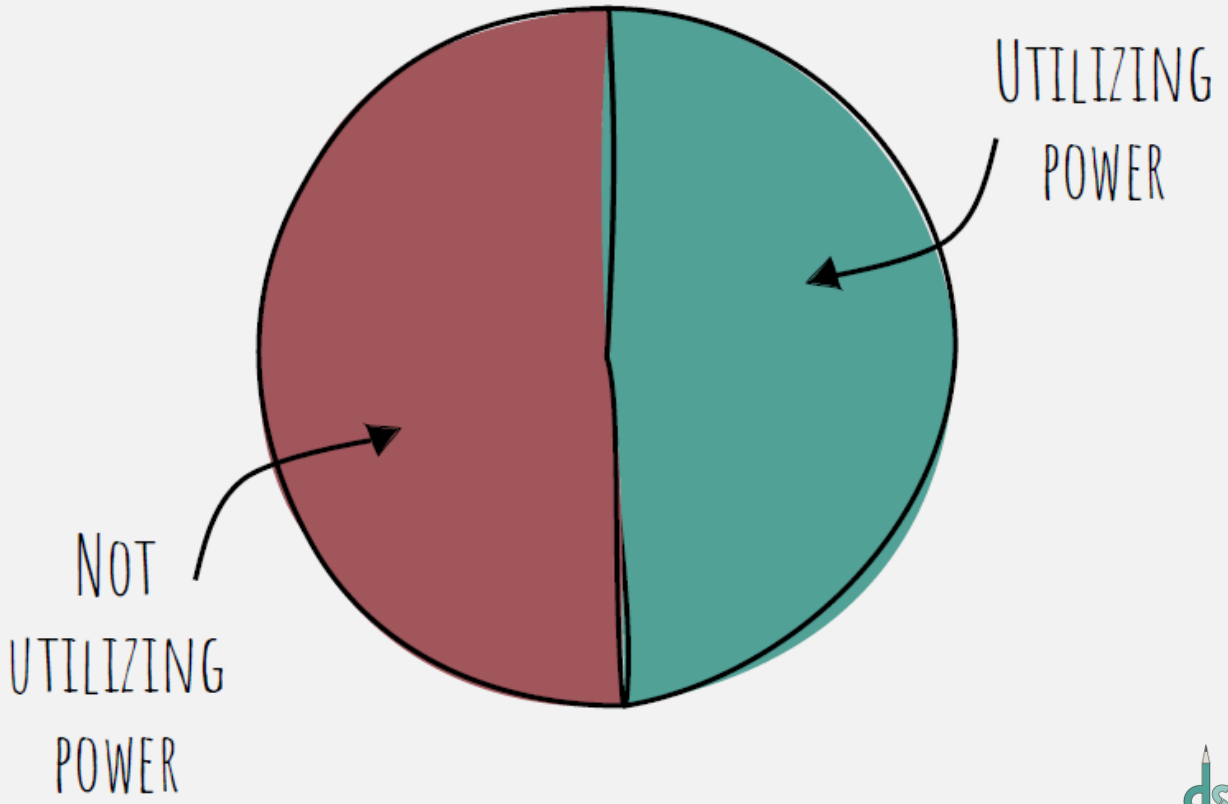
Influence of power does not have to be intentional

The attempted use of power that is outside that power's range will decrease the power of the authority

- I.e., new uses of power that are ineffectual reduce a person's power
- Conversely: New uses of power that are effectual increase a person's power.

The Power Conundrum

Things that Put our Power at Risk



The Bases of Social Power

French & Raven's classic model

- Reward Power
- Coercive Power
- Expert Power
- Referent Power
- Legitimate Power

What are your current, primary sources of social power?

I.e., why do people defer to you?

How might our own belief systems limit our influence?

Do we live in a "just world"?



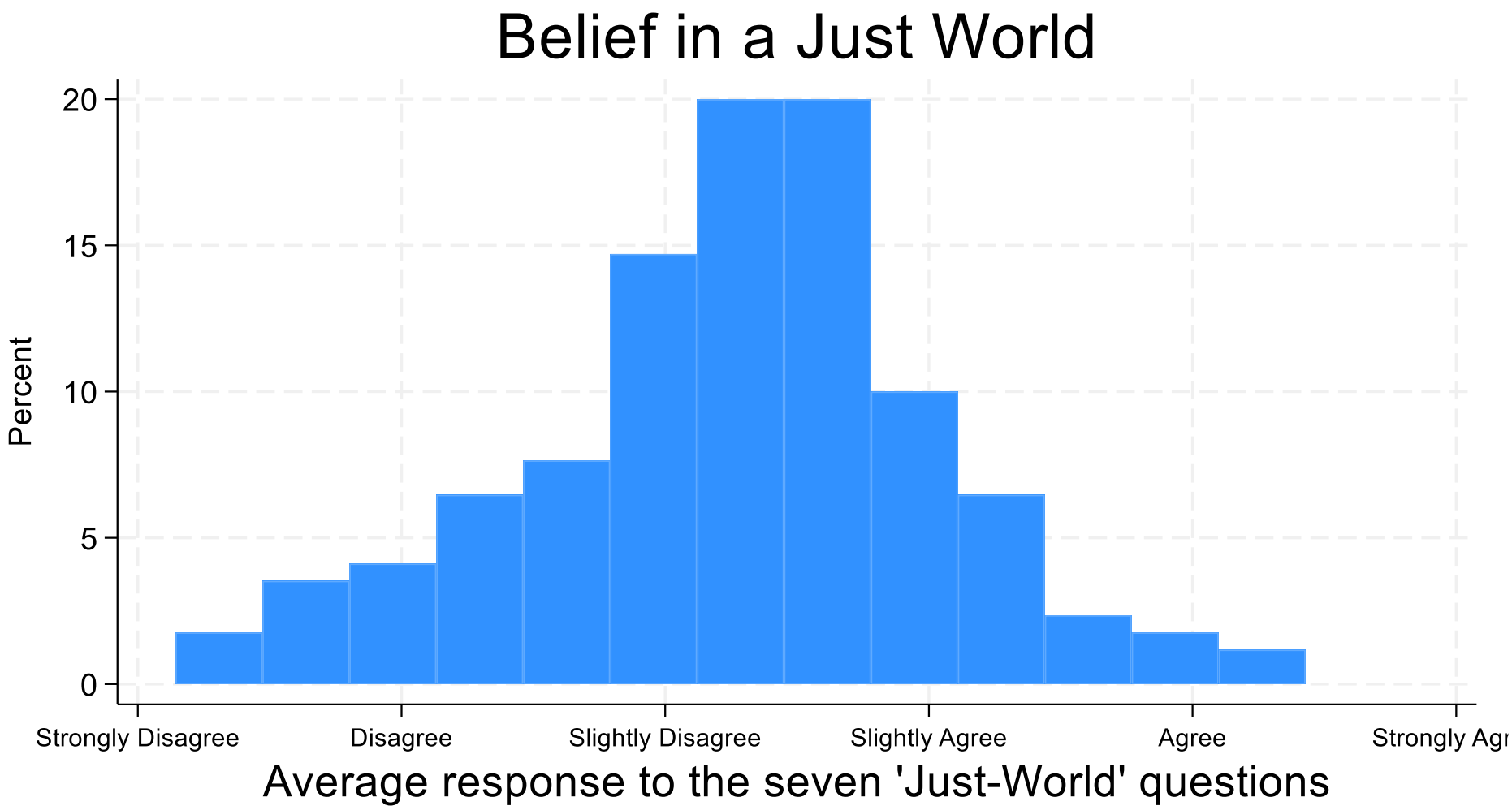
Lerner (1982): Most people believe that "people get what they deserve; that is, that the good people are likely to be rewarded and the bad to be punished."

Consequences?

Jeff Pfeffer: Just-World Beliefs…

- … anesthetize people to the need to be proactive in building a power base.
- … hinder people's ability to learn from all situations and all people, even those whom they don't like or respect.

Do you believe Pfeffer or the Chinese proverb, **"Peaches and plums do not have to talk, yet the world beats a path to them"**?

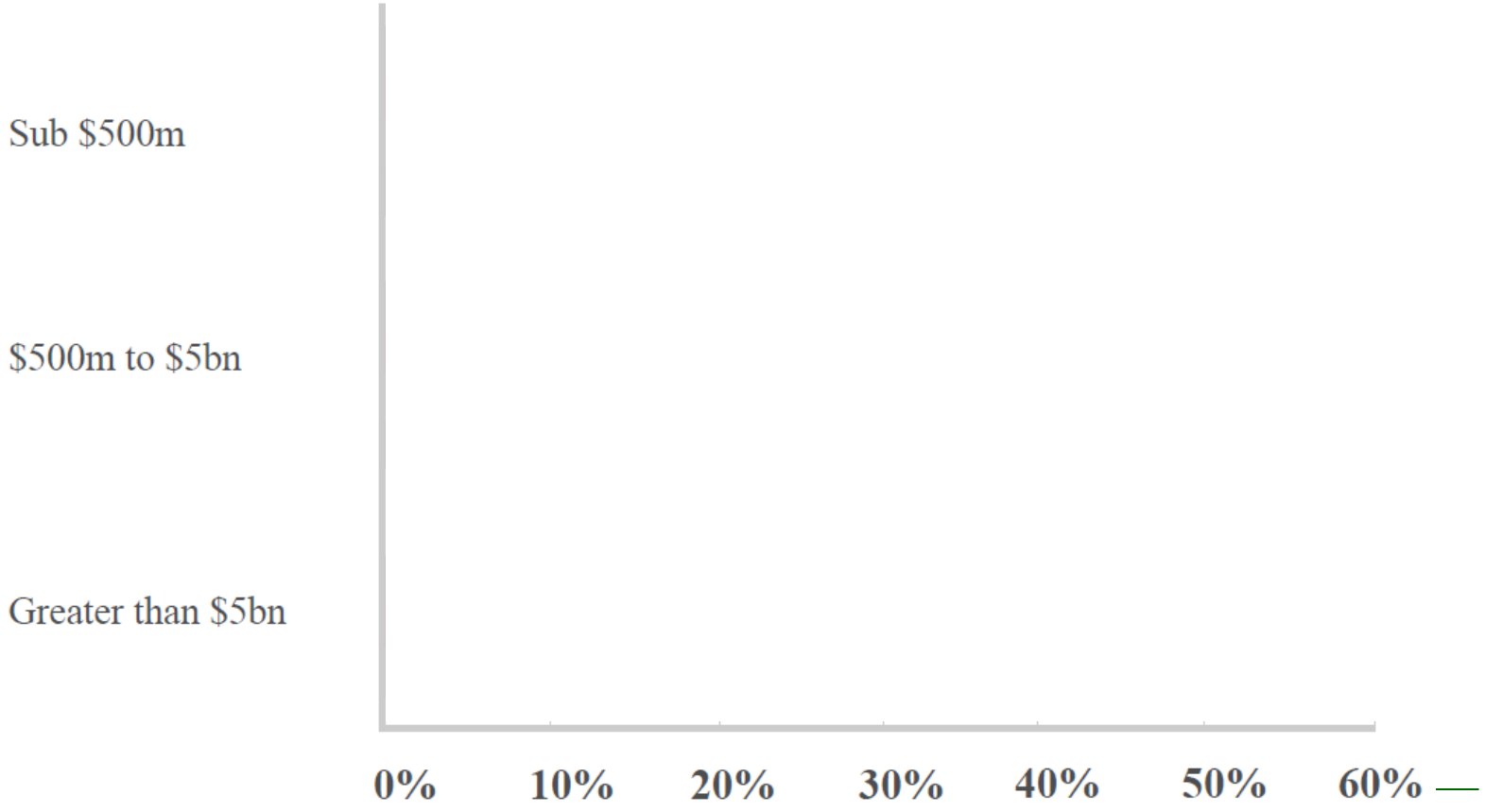


Fall 2025 MBAs. n=170.

2014 Survey of 174 Senior Execs

Written by The Economist Intelligence Unit

CHART 6: To what extent do you agree with the statement: "Company politics trump evidence in decision-making"?



Just World vs. Rough World

Just World	Rough World
Good things happen to good people, bad things happen to bad people.	Good and bad things happen to both good and bad people.
Hard work always pays off.	Hard work often pays off.
Good intentions are rewarded	Good intentions are sometimes considered
Merit trumps relationships	Merit and relationships matter.

We close with a two perspectives from very different times and places…

There are righteous ones who are treated according to the acts of the wicked,

and there are wicked ones treated according to the acts of the righteous.

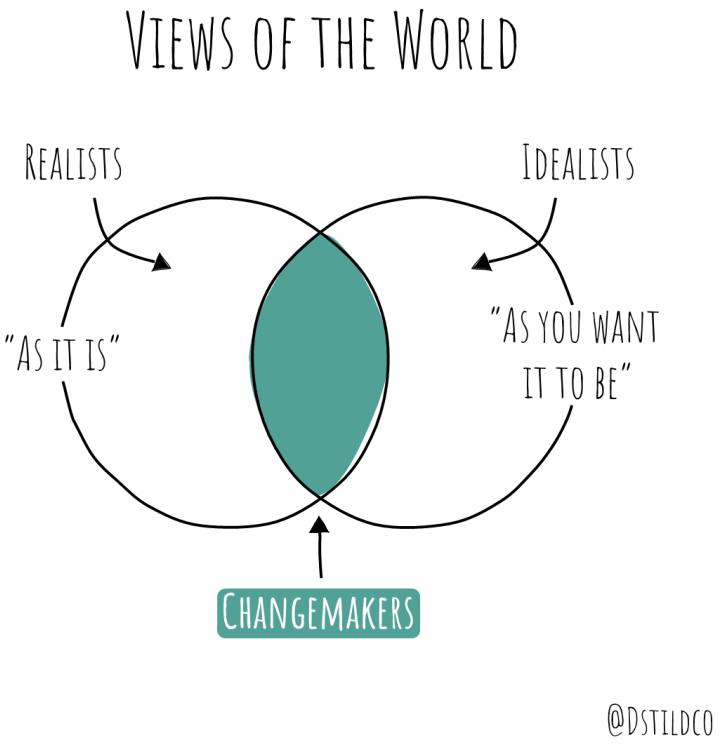
- Ecclesiastes 8:14

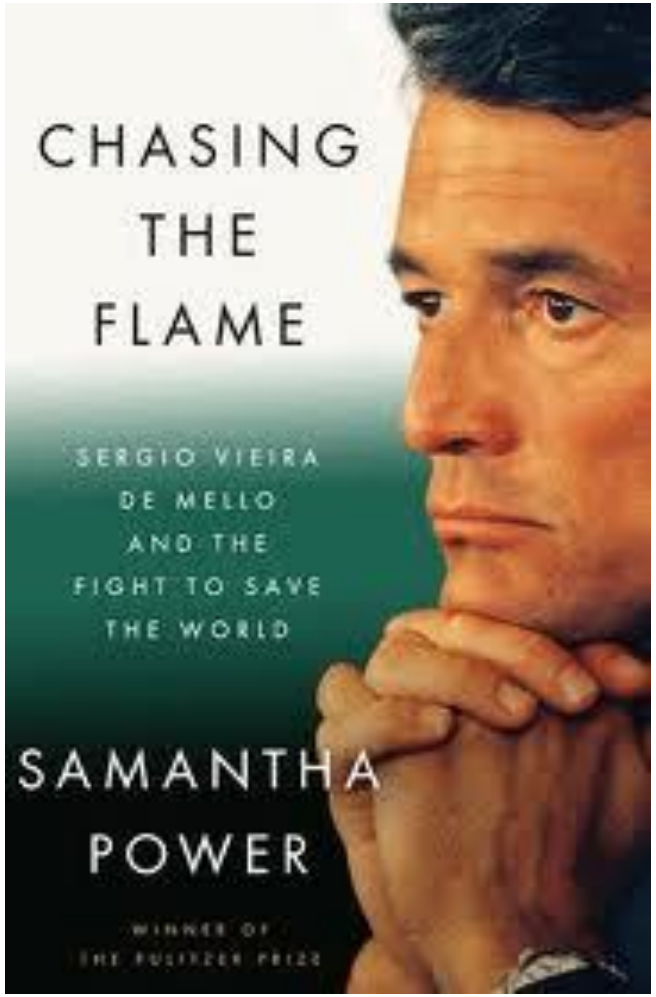

"The good ended happily, and the bad unhappily. That is what Fiction means."
Oscar Wilde, The Importance of Being Earnest

"Just World" and course philosophy

Our starting point for this course is seeing the world clearly. To be effective we need to be realistic.

I hope you're working to improve the world. But we have to start with where it is now.




CHASING
THE
FLAME
SERGIO VIEIRA
DE MELLO
AND THE
FIGHT TO SAVE
THE WORLD
SAMANTHA
POWER



SVDM memorial in Rio de Janeiro



Photo credit:
Alireza Salmanzadeh
(WG '23)

East Timor's independence

1999 UN backs a referendum in East Timor on independence from Indonesia.

East Timor votes for independence.

Indonesia razes the country on the way out.



East Timor's independence, destruction

"Nothing, literally nothing, had been left intact on the ground except the will of the Timorese."

"Airports and ports had to be opened, clean water procured, health care provided, schools resuscitated, a currency created, relations with Indonesia normalized, a constitution drafted, an official language chosen, and tax, customs and banking systems devised. Policies that normally evolved over hundreds of years would all have to be decided within months of arrival."



Sergio was well intentioned

Dedicated his life to the UN

Extensive experience working in hotspots around the world

Worked 19 hours days and weekends

Deeply interested in local staff and citizens

Was this sufficient to get the job done?

But he was severely hampered

Tough conditions

- 80% unemployment

His own organization was inflexible/unhelpful

- UN didn't have the expertise needed
  - Staff was "good at diplomatic cables, not laying electrical cable"
- UN regulations restrictive and inappropriate
  - 500 UN cars and barely 10 for Timorese leaders

Made some mistakes, inevitably

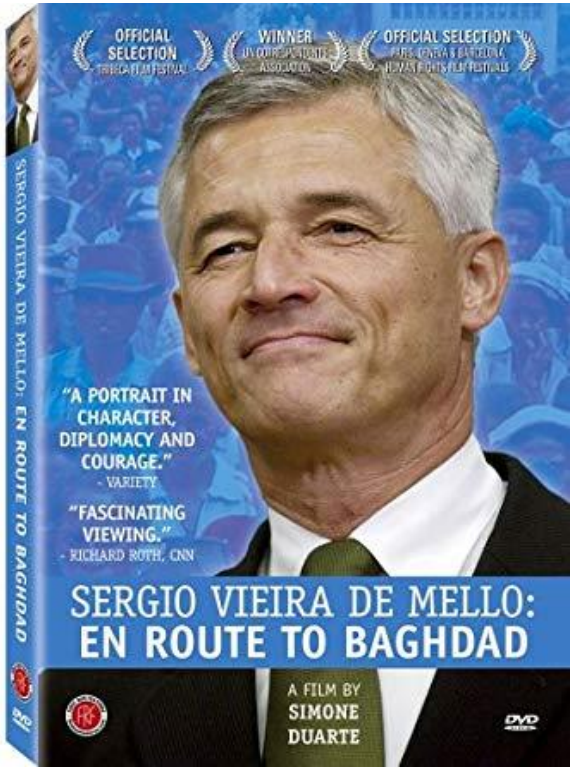
- Multiple mis-steps with the guerrilla army

And then the crisis worsened

Spring 2000 – brink of failure

- Physical security was breaking down
- Economy still in ruins
- Timorese began viewing UN as "second occupation"

SVDM on video







Reactions to Sergio?

De Mello Survey (random sample)

8:30 section

Tiger Huang	Minimizing the difference in living standards + security with the local population (i.e. no barbed wires around his residence, basic/dilapidated living conditions, not using sirens while driving)
Will Herbert	I thought his decision to defy the UN security council and establish a "co-government" with the Timorese was an interesting way to abstain from power.
Avi Jayaraman	I thought de Mello did a great job at trying to show his personal respects to the Timorese when he arrived. First, he took the two hour journey to Gusmao's town instead of waiting for him to come. He also made a huge effort to learn the local language, even going as far as having his speeches marked at key places for the right pauses and verbal effects.
Jerry Ren	Spreading power to other leaders after centralizing all power initially within the UN
Luisa Esteves	Sergio made a great emphasis to learn the local language (Tetum) and give speeches in the language as much as possible. He would practice his pronunciation to emphasize specific words and include local phrases. While doing this, Sergio would invite his aid, who would typically be driven in a separate car, to come with him in the car so they could practice. To me this gesture shows that he wanted to learn from locals, as well as that he was not "above" anyone.
Francie Middleton	There were many examples of Sergio being humble and trying to act like an average East Timorese person in order to cultivate trust in Sergio among the East Timorese. A small example was that he refused to use a siren to cut through traffic on the way to a meeting because he didn't want to look like a "king".
Dan Kanef	The decision that most stood out to me was Mello's decision to change the UN's role in the governance of Timor and give more power to local governing authorities - despite UN HQ resistance. Initially, the UN held most governing authority in the country. Due to the country's colonial history and other dynamics, locals found this paternalistic were not trusting of UN governance. Mello realized that he needed local trust and could only achieve this by advocating for more power for timorese leaders. He started a transition of power not fully in line with UN policy. It was risky, but build tremendous credibility and strengthened local confidence in the state-building efforts Mello drove.

De Mello Survey (random sample)

10:15 section

Ryan Winick	Sergio abstained from exercising his power in many ways that would have improved his and the UN international employee's quality of life. This includes living in rough conditions (the hotel with cockroaches) and limiting fun like the ship-board discoteque. This was clearly to avoid making a negative impression on the Timorese who were living in destitute conditions.
Ariana Katsanis	Mello brought himself to being like the everyman. This made him more approachable and likeable compared to the previous UN officials that entered the country. Mello took classes to learn the local language. Mello was also critical of how UN institutions behaved before him. He didn't like the fact the UN removed all materials and resources and could not extend any resources like vehicle and helicopters to locals. Mello got approval to get vehicles for local leaders as they would one day be running the country. This decision allowed Mello to help give these leaders legitimacy to others in the UN and show mutual respect. Mello also leaned on the expertise of locals which was seemingly unfamiliar to the typical UN procedure to "dump internationals into the situation"
Madison Chen	Vieira de Mello tried to keep government structures / positions of power as accessible to the general public as possible, making it seem less intimidating. For example, he kept the Governor's House readily accessible to locals and forbade the UN chief of administration from adding a barbed wire fence to the compound, even though these measures would certainly reinforce safety and power.
Anika Limaye	Sergio de Mello's choice to centralize authority under the UN Transitional Administration instead of immediately sharing power with Timorese leaders after Indonesia's withdrawal
Bhavya Shah	Sergio was a unique proponent towards the cause for neutrality and justness. I think one of the key ways he approached this was having the personal presence in situations of need. Sergio chose to meet directly with Timorese (for example meeting with Xanana). This is one example / instance of his direct involvement in the process. He chose to use diplomacy, personal presence instead of enforcing authority, to foster trust among complexities of the situation that existed.

De Mello Survey (random sample)

1:45 section

Andrew Herbst	Convinced the UN agency to remit payment to local families of those killed in the 1999 conflict despite lack of ID information.
Frank Mork	Sergio cultivated power by taking the time to learn the local language.
Brian Gerevits	One standout action was Sergio's determination to persuade UN leadership to let Timor leverage UN resources. Securing funding to repair roads in East Timor and to support civil service operations were a major breakthrough in UN-Timor relations and in the country's own ability to self-govern.
Andrea Delgado	Keeping a low profile and trying to bled in via actions like refusing a large villa and learning the local language
Lena Gandevia	As his bodyguard notes, Sergio "didn't like to live in ways other people couldn't" -- Sergio went out of his way to be one of the Timorese - he spent time learning their language, went out of his way to meet Gusmao, declined to live in the fancy accommodations the UN had set up for him when plenty of the people had no where to live, etc.
Sean Lerner	Backing his Malaysian COS (and Xanana's) decision to not prosecute war criminals.
Ashley Chen	I appreciate how Sergio de Mello did his best to live like the general public, rather than an important official. For instance, he didn't put a siren on his vehicle to get around more quickly, he stayed in a very humble hotel and utilized fancy quarters as hotel rooms for international visitors, and learned to speak their language correctly to win over their support.
Matt Goodman	de Mello organized for law and order to be established in East Timor, having the UN canvasing across the country to identify potential judicial representatives. In a moving ceremony, de Mello handed out black robes to 8 judges and 2 prosecutors at the burned out courthouse in Dili (one of which was FALINTIL). In doing so, he placed judicial power in the hands of the locals instead of with an international organization.
Mike Woods	One of the most decisive actions Sergio took was to appoint Timorese officials to positions of power over the UN officials. He appointed the Timorese to run the departments of the internal administrations, economic affairs, social affairs, and infrastructure. He made it clear that the Timorese had power in this transition by holding a conference of around 700 people to identify them as the bosses of other UN officials. When met with resistance from the UN Headquarters, he surprised them during a video conference by inviting the Timorese appointed to these positions to the video conference.

Small-group discussion question

Is Sergio de Mello's experience in East Timor relevant to your corporate life?

Sergio vs. Mitch (the fire analyst)?

A few specific take-aways from de Mello…

Takeaway #1: Focus on legitimacy

Informal power is separate from formal power

Participation as a source of legitimacy

- E.g., Pamphlets from airplanes to recruit lawyers?!

His primary motivation for bending UN rules

"VDM had learned a valuable lesson about legitimacy: it was performance based. 'The UN cannot presume that it will be seen as legitimate by the local population in question just because in some distant Security Council chamber a piece of paper was produced. We need to show why we are beneficial to the people on the ground, and we need to show that quickly.'" (p341)

Ultimately, legitimacy=f(performance)

Pfeffer: Power depends on the reputation for being effective.

- Influence in organizations is self-fulfilling
  - What happens early is critical

Robert Moses example

- Judge Lutsky, next page, from Caro's 1992 book (p143)

Judge Jacob Lutsky (served 4 mayors)

"You've got to understand – every morning when a mayor comes to work, there are a hundred problems that must be solved. And a lot of them are so big and complex that they just don't seem susceptible to solution. And when he asks guys for solutions, what happens? Most of them can't give him any. And those that do come up with solutions, the solutions are unrealistic or impractical –or just plain stupid...

"But you give a problem to Moses and overnight he's back in front of you – with a solution, all worked out down to the last detail, drafts of speeches you can give to explain it to the public, drafts of press releases for the newspapers, drafts of the state laws you'll need to get passed, advice as to who should introduce the bills in the Legislature and what committees they should go to, drafts of any City Council and Board of Estimate resolutions you'll need; if there are constitutional questions involved, a list of the relevant precedents –and a complete method of financing, are all spelled out.

"He had solutions when no one else had solutions."

Takeaway #2: Invest in relationships

Prioritized the dignity of the citizens

- "Local staff members were unaccustomed to being treated with such respect by foreigners."

"Went to the jungle"

- One day after his 24-hour trip to arrive in East Timor, de Mello made a 2-hour trip via steep, unpaved mountain roads to visit guerilla leader, Xanana Gusmao.

Takeaway #3: Symbolism matters

Put symbolism over convenience

- Removed the barbed-wire fencing around the UN compound
- "I'd rather be late than act like a king"

He worked on substance, but he also recognized the power of symbolism.

Mike Useem: "leaders are always on stage"

Takeaway #4: Value of flexibility

"Be multiple"

- E.g., muscular with Indonesians, participative with East Timorese
- E.g., "Timorization" – Coercive with the UN in order to cede power to local officials.
- E.g., Direct pressure (family reparations) vs. working through others (Australian oil)

"Ruthless pragmatism" (p9)

Re flexibility: Two types of power

British diplomat 1969-2004 – US, France, Dubai, Saudi Arabia.

British ambassador to the UN 1998-2003.

Chairman of the Security Council's Counter-Terrorism Committee.

"[Sergio] had vast reserves of both charm and steel."



Sir Jeremy Greenstock

2-factor model of power

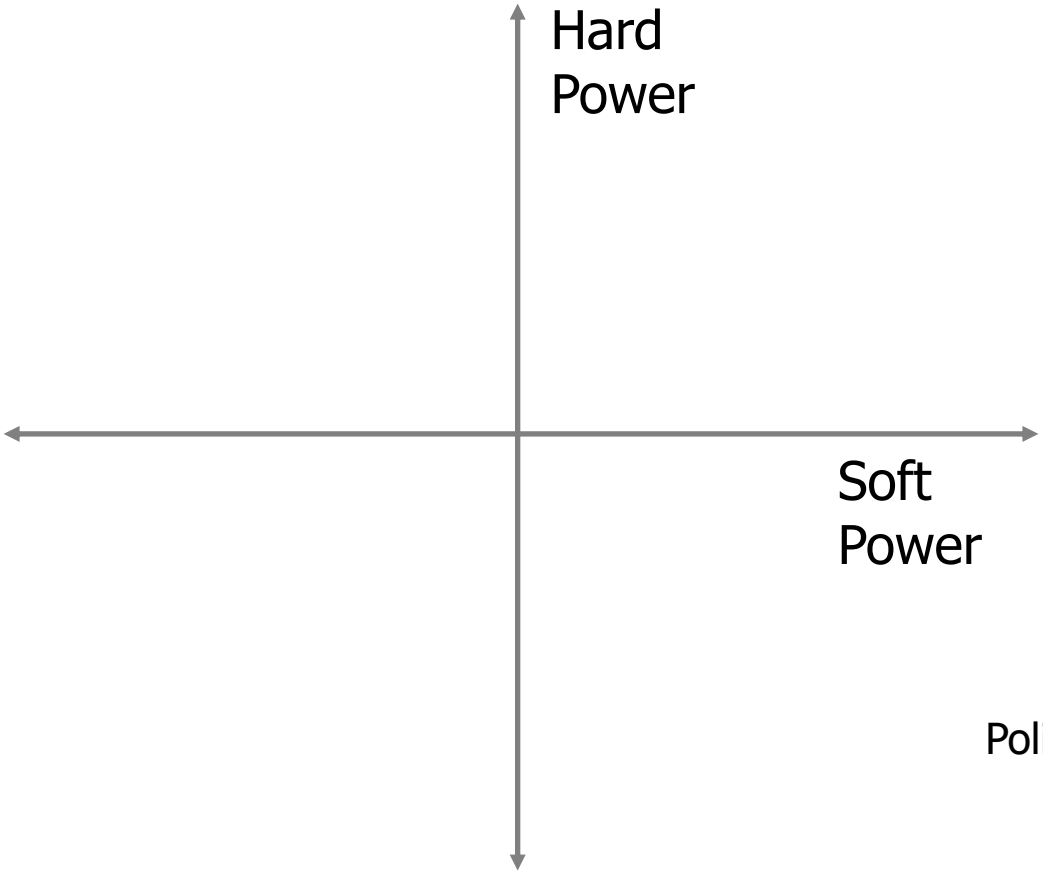
Hard Power (de Mello's "steel")

- Def (Massey): The ability and willingness to impose costs on others
- Some tactics we'll explore:
  - Might, ethos

Soft Power (de Mello's "charm")

- Def (Nye): The ability to get others to want what you want
- Some tactics we'll explore:
  - Networks, coalitions, team-building, exchange, allocentrism, pathos

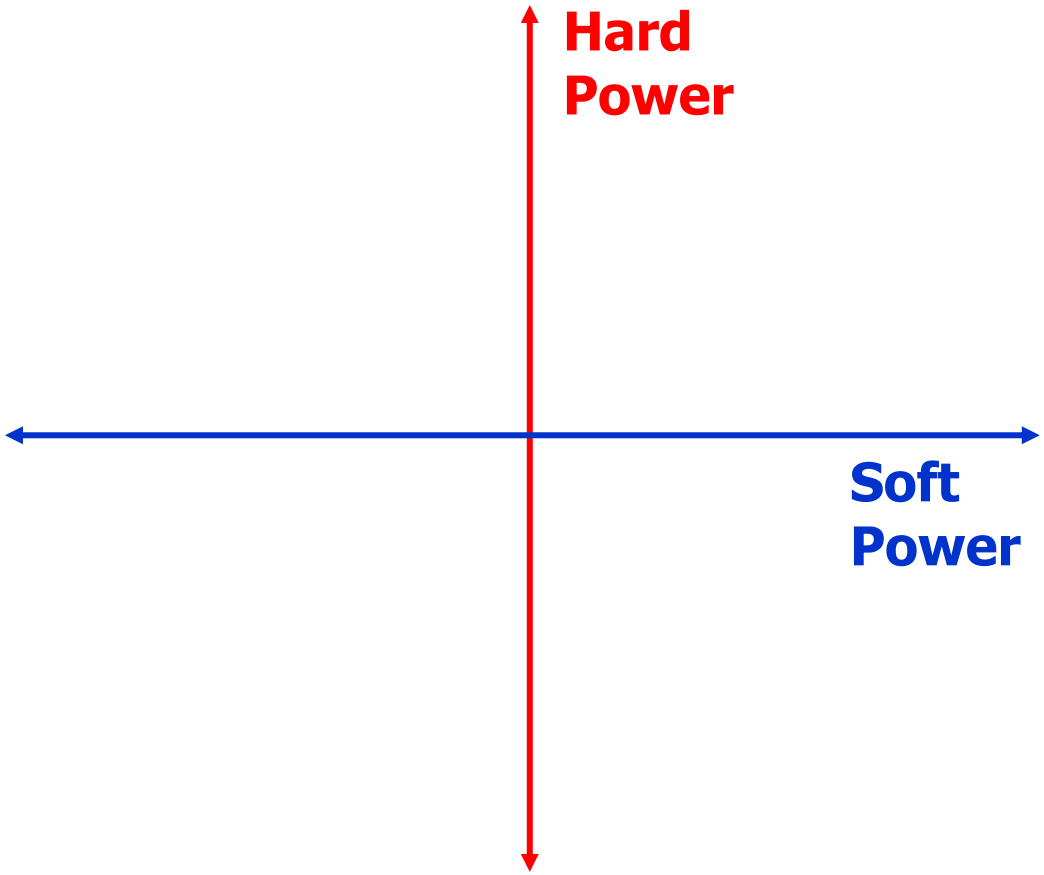
Ubiquitous 2-factor model of power



Some Manifestations

Political Science: Soft-Hard Power
Education: Support-Challenge
Economics: Cooperate-Defect
Psychology: Warmth-Competence
Sikhism: Saint-Soldier

Does the 2-factor model explain SVDM's success?



What does S. Power mean here?

"[Sergio] started out as a humanitarian, but by 2003 he had become a diplomat and politician, comfortable weighing lesser evils."

(p12)

Takeaway #5: Recognize need for trade-offs

E.g., security vs. human rights

- "Human rights? Human rights? That is Alice in Wonderland. We have to deal with reality here." (Ramos-Horta, p317)

E.g., stability vs. immediate justice

- McNamara: "Sergio, you've become like a bloody politician. How can you just let the killers go free?" (p327)

SVDM knew his priorities and was intentional in pursuing them.

Intentionality

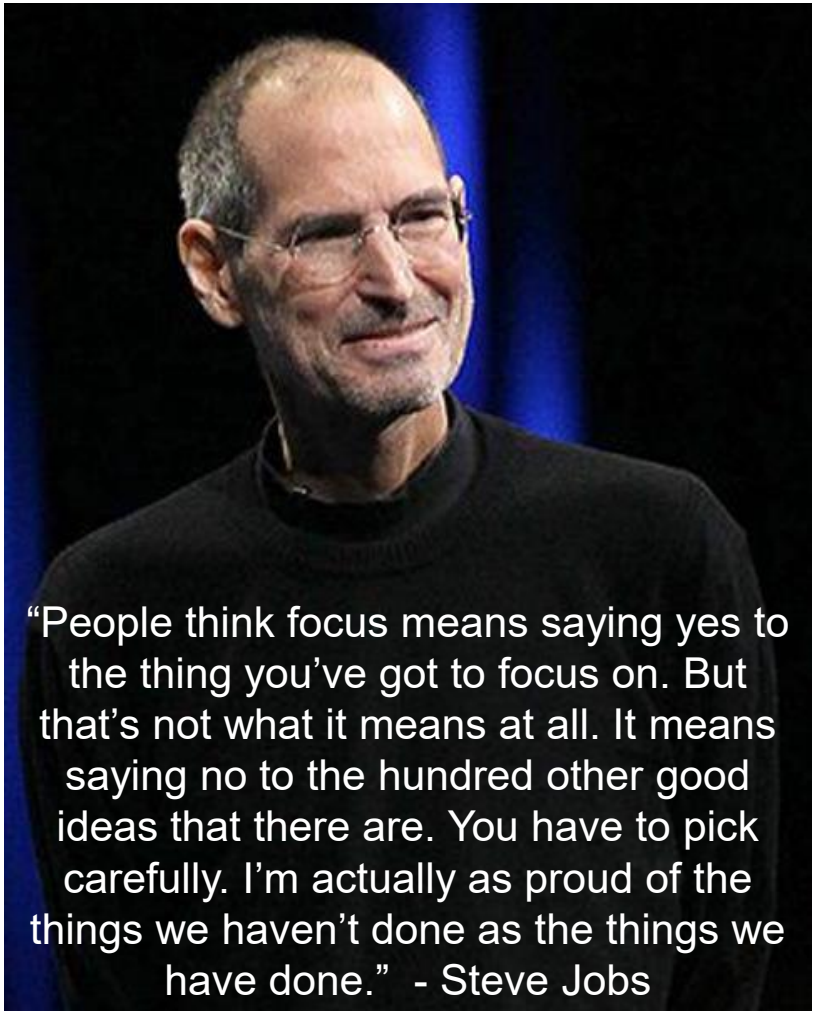
(See today's appendix for more on intentionality)

Def: Acting with a goal in mind.

Heuristic: You're not truly committed to a goal unless you are sacrificing lesser goals.

Are you working to a plan? Are you working to completion?

Do you understand the trade-offs required?



A closing thought

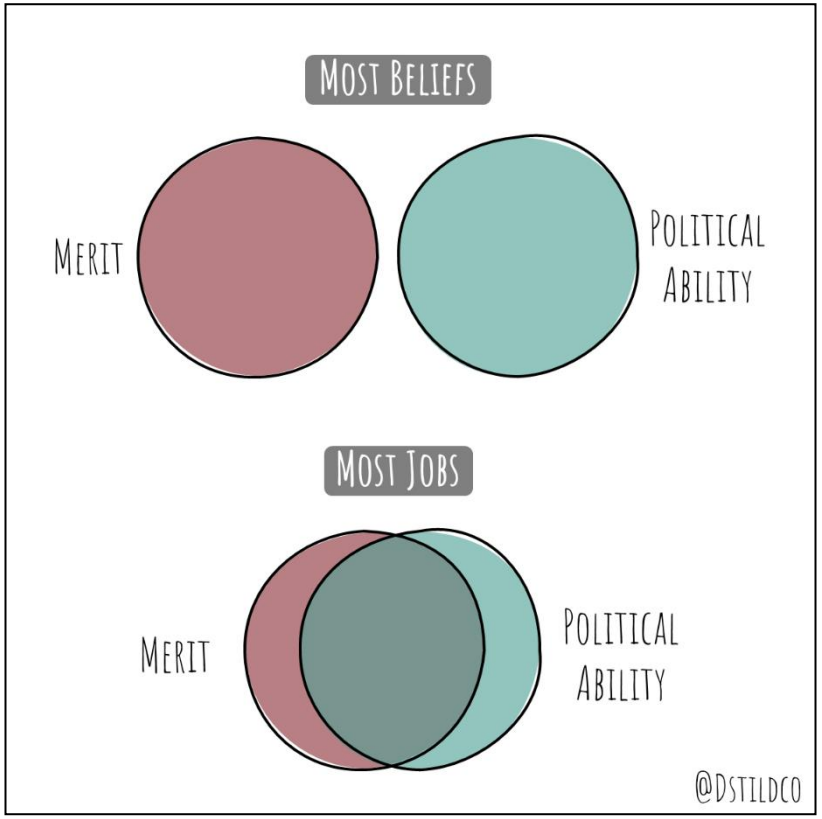
Political Scientist Jonathan Koppell:

"People often worry about politics as a substitute for merit.

But if manipulating rules and working within rules are keys to success,

and doing so is considered politics,

perhaps political ability <u>is</u> merit."



To sum, a few specific take-aways from de Mello…

1. Focus on legitimacy
2. Invest in relationships
3. Symbolism matters in leadership
4. Be multiple (in methods)
5. Recognize need for trade-offs

BTW, are these traits or behaviors?

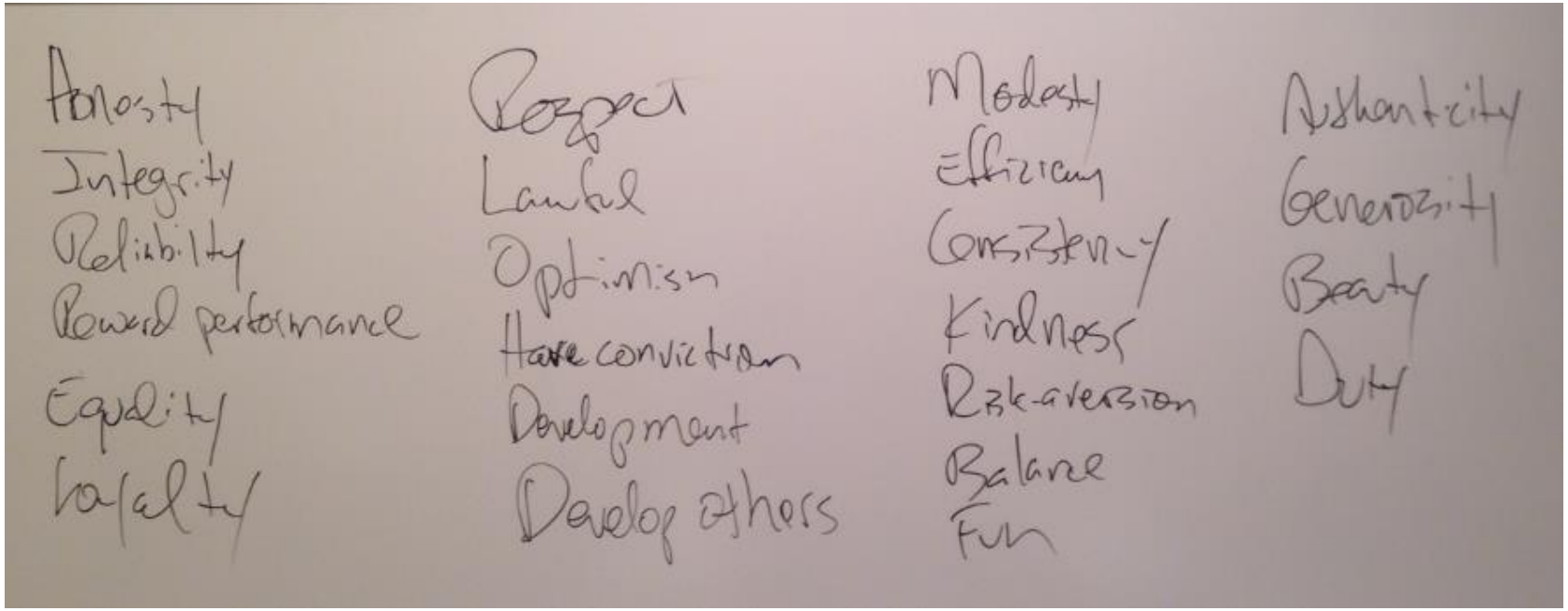
Appendix

On Principles

Abstract ideas that govern behavior across situations.

- Useful in providing direction
- A source of utility in and of themselves
- Can engender respect from others
- And: Constrain your choices

What principles guide your behavior?



Principles vs. Pragmatism?

"[Otto von Bismarck] disparaged theory and principle as yardsticks for political life. The result was a freedom from ideological constraints that made his behaviour unpredictable – one could call it realism, pragmatism or opportunism – an ability to spring from one camp to another, wrong-footing his opponents."



"'If I am to proceed through life on the basis of principles, it is as if I were to walk down a narrow path in the woods with a long pole in my mouth.'"

- Christopher Clark, Iron Kingdom, p521

What is / is not worth fighting for?

Effectiveness often requires flexibility and compromise. Idealism is costly.

- E.g., de Mello doesn't repatriate 400,000 Cambodian refugees without sitting down with the Khmer Rouge.

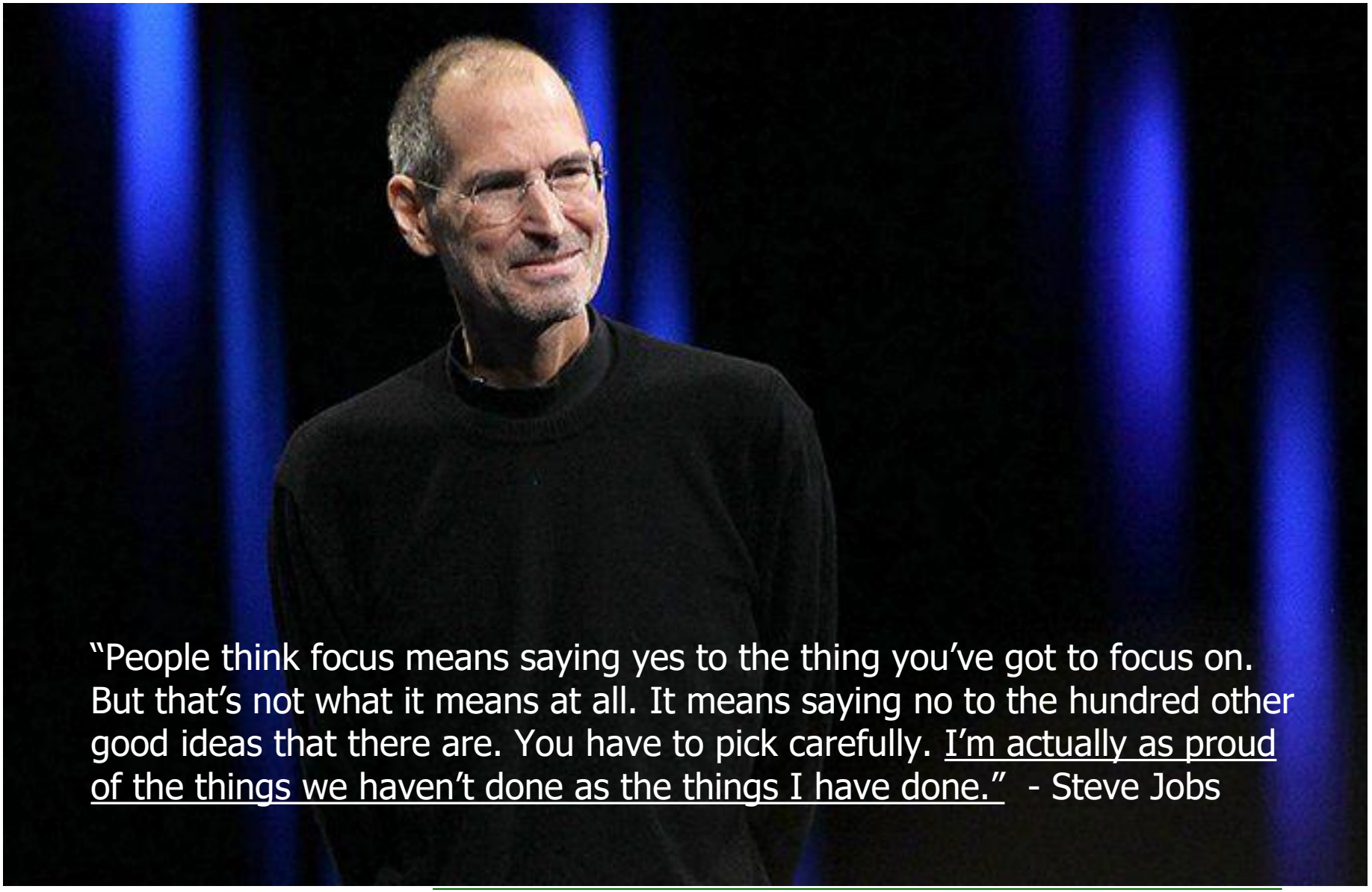
But to be without principles, or to have them moved around by external forces, invites trouble.

- Suggests you need to know which lines you will not cross. What principles will you not sacrifice? What is your hierarchy?

On Intentionality

Definition: Acting with a goal in mind

Heuristic: You're not truly committed to a goal unless you're sacrificing lesser goals.


"People think focus means saying yes to the thing you've got to focus on. But that's not what it means at all. It means saying no to the hundred other good ideas that there are. You have to pick carefully. I'm actually as proud of the things we haven't done as the things I have done." - Steve Jobs

Warren Buffet's "20 slot" rule

Via Charlie Munger, Stanford Business School, 1994:

"When Warren lectures at business schools, he says, 'I could improve your ultimate financial welfare by giving you a ticket with only 20 slots in it so that you had 20 punches—representing all the investments that you got to make in a lifetime. And once you'd punched through the card, you couldn't make any more investments at all.'

"He says, 'Under those rules, you'd really think carefully about what you did and you'd be forced to load up on what you'd really thought about. So you'd do so much better.'

"Again, this is a concept that seems perfectly obvious to me. And to Warren it seems perfectly obvious. But this is one of the very few business classes in the U.S. where anybody will be saying so. It just isn't the conventional wisdom.

"To me, it's obvious that the winner has to bet very selectively. It's been obvious to me since very early in life. I don't know why it's not obvious to very many other people."

E.g., VCs who lose focus suffer

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The effect of venture capitalists straying from their industry comfort zones

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Venture capital
Specialization
Industry experience

ABSTRACT

I empirically test and find evidence that venture capital industry experience is more informative and impactful in venture capital investment when measured at the low non-aggregated industry level. Additional evidence shows that venture capital investments made outside of a venture capitalist's preferred investment industry suffer from significant decreases in exit success likelihood. This effect becomes stronger the more distant the investment industry is from the venture capitalist's preferred investment industry.

Steinbeck, on his expedition to the Sea of Cortez, 1940:

"Hitler marched into Denmark and into Norway, France had fallen, the Maginot Line was lost – we didn't know it, but we knew the daily catch of every boat within four hundred miles. It was simply a directional thing; a man has only so much."



The Log from the Sea of Cortez (Ch 1), 1941/1951

On Intentionality

Soren Kierkegaard:

A saint is “someone who can will the one thing”.

(See appendix for a short meditation by Ronald Rolheiser on this quote in which he contrasts Mother Teresa with Janis Joplin!)

So, how is your focus?





James Clear
@JamesClear

Six months from now, what you will you wish you had spent time on today?

9:00 AM · Jan 2, 2023

Rolheiser, from Holy Longing

"A saint is someone who can, precisely, channel powerful eros in a creative, life-giving way. **Søren Kierkegaard once defined a saint as someone who can will the one thing.** Nobody disputes that Mother Teresa did just that, willed the one thing—God and the poor. She had a powerful energy, but it was a very disciplined one. Her fiery eros was poured out for God and the poor. That—total dedication of everything to God and poor—was her signature, her spirituality. It made her what she was. Looking at Janis Joplin, the rock star who died from an overdose of life at age twenty-seven, few would consider her a very spiritual woman. Yet she was one. People think of her as the opposite of Mother Teresa, erotic, but not spiritual. Yet Janis Joplin was not so different from Mother Teresa, at least not in raw makeup and character. She was also an exceptional woman, a person of fiery eros, a great lover, a person with a rare energy. Unlike Mother Teresa, however, Janis Joplin could not will the one thing. She willed many things. Her great energy went out in all directions and eventually created an excess and a tiredness that led to an early death. But those activities—a total giving over to creativity, performance, drugs, booze, sex, coupled with the neglect of normal rest—were her spirituality. This was her signature. It was how she channeled her eros. In her case, as is tragically often the case in gifted artists, the end result, at least in this life, was not a healthy integration but a dissipation. She, at a point, simply lost the things that normally glue a human person together and broke apart under too much pressure. Looking at Joplin's life, and at our own lives, there is an interesting reflection to be made on Kierkegaard's definition of being a saint—someone who can will the one thing. Most of us are quite like Mother Teresa in that we want to will God and the poor. We do will them. The problem is we will everything else as well. Thus, we want to be a saint, but we also want to feel every sensation experienced by sinners; we want to be innocent and pure, but we also want to be experienced and taste all of life; we want to serve the poor and have a simple lifestyle, but we also want all the comforts of the rich; we want to have the depth afforded by solitude, but we also do not want to miss anything; we want to pray, but we also want to watch television, read, talk to friends, and go out. Small wonder life is often a trying enterprise and we are often tired and pathologically overextended**. Medieval philosophy had a dictum that said: Every choice is a renunciation.** Indeed. Every choice is a thousand renunciations. To choose one thing is to turn one's back on many others. To marry one person is to not marry all the others, to have a baby means to give up certain other things; and to pray may mean to miss watching television or visiting with friends. This makes choosing hard. No wonder we struggle so much with commitment. It is not that we do not want certain things, it is just that we know that if we choose them we close off so many other things. It is not easy to be a saint, to will the one thing, to have the discipline of a Mother Teresa. The danger is that we end up more like Janis Joplin; good-hearted, highly energized, driven to try to drink in all of life, but in danger of falling apart and dying from lack of rest."